

Leadership and Change Group Work Project Brief:

Developing an Organizational Change Plan

Please note that this group work is designed to facilitate your reflective learning on the module. You will have a chance to receive feedback during your timetabled SLW in Week 8 by presenting your group work in class. Please note that this will not be assessed, but it's your opportunity to receive feedback. This activity is, in fact, designed to help you prepare parts three and four of your reflective learning portfolio for the module. Part three includes your design for a change plan, which can use work and insights from the group project but should be your own individual work, as the group work per se is not assessed. The process of working in a team on this project should also give you material for part four of the portfolio, as you reflect upon the leadership dynamics that emerged in your group.

For the group work this year you will be working on a *fictional* project. This is not a real case study, and ARU is not currently considering AI for marking students work. We have developed this assignment using realistic sources (please find the document titled 'Additional Sources on AI and Education') and chosen a contentious topic to give you the opportunity to work on a realistic and relevant change project, that relates to your own role as a student at the university, and that contains multiple stakeholder perspectives.

The Brief

Cheryl Buntington-Smythe, the Chief Organization and Operations Officer (COOO) of Awfully Realistic University (ARU) has brought your consultancy team in to develop an organizational change plan for her. She has been following the development of AI applications and large language models (LLMs) with some excitement and sees these as a potential source of efficiency savings in the University. So far, these experiments have focussed on using AI to write up the minutes of meetings and draft reports. It has mostly been used by Administrative Services and Support staff or management, including in staff performance and evaluation reporting. So far, the results of these experiments have been inconclusive. People seem to like using the technology but the savings in staff time don't really seem to be coming through so Cheryl wants to take ARU's use of AI to the next level and really position the University at the forefront of innovation in higher education by using the latest generation of LLMs to provide feedback and grades for student's assignments.

In the project brief she has talked about the benefits to students, as AI can provide feedback and grades almost immediately, but also hinted at efficiency savings. She has also mentioned that staff don't really enjoy marking, especially on large modules, and

despite the anonymous marking policy, she has some concerns that ‘human markers’ can be inconsistent: ‘If you’re marking 200 assignments, it is hard to maintain a perfectly objective and consistent perspective. AI can help with that as it doesn’t get tired and will only focus on the content. We know that markers are sometimes influenced by presentation and well-written essays, but really, they should only be looking at the substance and student’s understanding of the subject.’

During the briefing she also mentioned the financial pressures on the University. Since Brexit, the number of EU students coming to study at ARU have fallen, and the last government’s focus on reducing migration created a ‘hostile environment’ for students, making it harder for them to secure visas to study in the UK and reducing the number of international students at the University. The UK government has also kept fees fixed at £9000 since full fees were introduced in 2012, but inflation has eroded the value of those fees to universities as income has not risen alongside costs. Together, these three factors have created a ‘perfect storm’ for the university and pushing departments to make ever more demanding ‘efficiency savings’. Cheryl also wants to build up a larger operating surplus, so she can recruit more people into marketing and grow student numbers, especially in international markets where competition is ever more intense. This means cutting costs, and staff are the largest cost for the university. If AI can reduce the workloads, the staffing budget can be reduced too, allowing the university to invest in more ‘value adding’ activities like recruitment.

As you were leaving her office, the COOO asked you to exercise discretion when talking to people about this project. In a recent dispute over pay-awards with the University and Colleges Union (UCU) – the body representing the academic staff in Universities – the Union combined strike days with an assessment boycott in an attempt to pressure the University into a pay award that was a little bit closer to inflation. Cheryl seemed worried that the union would have a very negative perception of proposals for AI for assessment and grading, as it would remove the possibility of them threatening an assessment boycott in future pay negotiations. She clearly thought that would be a good thing for ‘the University’ but something that unionised academics might not be happy about.

The Project

Cheryl is expecting you to present your Change Plan to her in three weeks. She wants to understand how she can lead this change effective and ensure that it ‘lands’ and takes root. She is particularly interested in understanding:

- 1 – What are the main drivers and barriers at work in the organization?
- 2 - How can barriers be overcome, and drivers used to make the change happen?

3 – What are the key stakeholders for this change process, both within and outside the organization?

4 – How should the change be communicated to stakeholders?

She would also like a clear, step-by-step plan for managing the change process (5) so your presentation should have at least 5 slides to cover these topics. Cheryl is an extremely busy woman, however, so you will only have 10 minutes to make your pitch. If you run over the 10 minutes allocated, she will cut you off and you have lost the contract!

Resources

To help you with this project you have a team of researchers who have gathered some of the data for you already. On your canvas pages there are resources that will help you understand who the key stakeholders and what they think. These include:

- A collection of short quotes from an early consultation exercise that was recently completed, with comments on AI in universities from students and staff in a range of different positions, as well as members of advisory boards and employer consultation fora.
- An interview with the President of the Students' Union – the body responsible for representing student voice.
- An interview with the President of ARU's University and Colleges Union – the body that represents the academic members of staff.

You are not allowed to undertake primary research as a part of this groupwork, so you can't do a survey or interviews yourself, but you can use the internet to search for evidence of what external stakeholders might think, for example the webpages of University's UK (UUK) the body that represents the vice-chancellors of UK universities; the CIPD (the Chartered Institute of Personnel and Development) or other professional bodies; Trade Unions; Employers' associations like the Chambers of Commerce or Confederation of British Industry. You can also look through quality media articles in the Financial Times, The Economists, or the Times Higher Education, for general articles about AI and education/employment.